

Negative Space

Seeing the shapes around the subject

Negative space is the area around and between subjects — the 'empty' space. Because it has no meaning to your brain, it's easier to draw accurately than the subject itself. Learning to use it is a powerful accuracy tool.

KEY CONCEPTS

Why It Works

When you look at a hand, your brain sees 'hand' and tries to draw what it knows, not what it sees. When you look at the triangular gap between two fingers, your brain just sees a shape — and draws it accurately.

Silhouette as Negative Space

Looking at the silhouette of a subject is looking at where the subject meets the negative space. The edge of the silhouette is defined equally by the subject and the background. Use the background shape to check the silhouette.

Negative Space Thumbnails

Make a quick thumbnail of just the negative spaces in a composition. Fill in the negative spaces as solid shapes. This forces you to see proportions as flat shapes, not as meaningful objects.

Checking with Negative Space

After establishing your positive shapes, look at the negative spaces you've created. Do they match the reference? Mismatched negative spaces reveal proportion errors in the positive shapes.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw the shapes of shadows and gaps in a still life — don't draw the objects.
 2. Draw a chair by filling in all the negative space (the gaps between legs, etc.).
 3. Look at a face: draw only the triangular shapes between the features.
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FURTHER READING

■ Betty Edwards – Negative Space

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vza7ow1n8UQ>

■ Proko – Negative Space Concept

<https://youtu.be/nJ6QivnCQqg>